Visual storytelling with archetypes: how single-image content can tell cohesive and consistent brand stories

Joachim Scholz and Antonia Mantonakis
Goodman School of Business, Brock University, St. Catharines, Canada, and
Jacob Gigliotti
Pillitteri Estates Winery, Niagara-on-the-Lake, Canada

Abstract

Purpose – Despite the rise of visual content in marketing practice, guidance on visual storytelling remains scarce. Integrating neo-archetypal theory with practice theory, this paper examines whether archetypes can facilitate the translation of specific plot-based brand stories into still images, and how managers can select single-image content to create cohesive and consistent articulations of archetypes over time.

Design/methodology/approach – This paper examines the use of archetypes in visual storytelling at both outcome (i.e. how well brands enact archetypes) and process-levels (i.e. what managerial actions and thought patterns drive variations in archetype consistency): The study performs a critical visual analysis of 1,244 Instagram posts across seven wine brands to identify dominant character archetypes expressed through these images. Furthermore, the study conducts 10 depth interviews with representatives of the seven brands and professional storytellers to examine how managers select images to tell brand stories.

Findings – Findings demonstrate that archetypes can align meanings between plot-based brand stories and visual content. The study finds that some brands are more consistent than others in their archetypal enactments, and details how these differences are produced by competing teleoaffective structures that either promote or inhibit alignments of archetypal meanings.

Originality/value – The study findings contribute to the literatures on visual storytelling and archetypal marketing by advancing understandings of (a) the role of archetypes in visual storytelling (i.e. archetypes can express differentiated and nuanced brand meanings, but they must be enrolled in storytelling practices to affect how marketers act and what makes sense for them to do) and (b) how a visual mix is articulated in marketing practice (i.e. how competing goals can be balanced and what dangers are posed by overly emphasizing customer engagement metrics).

Keywords Social media, Storytelling, Branding, Practice theory, Content marketing, Archetypes, Critical visual analysis

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

Imagine you are browsing Instagram on a lazy Friday afternoon: You see sponsored posts for two wine brands and, being intrigued, you check out both profiles. Scanning through the images of the first brand, you get a clear picture of "who this wine is", as every single image exudes a sense of adventure you are seeking to embody in your own life. The second brand, on the other hand, seems to be "all over the map". Later at the store, you pick up the first wine brand for Sunday's beach picnic. For marketers, the goal is clear, but the path is not:

Q1. They want to be the brand that people can instantly understand and relate to, but how can they ensure that every image they post tells their story?

While storytelling has been central to branding strategies for quite some time (Woodside *et al.*, 2008), visual storytelling with little to no copy text has become prevalent only more recently (Grigsby *et al.*, 2023; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Lim and Childs, 2020; Nikulina *et al.*, 2024). Media agencies have noted "a sharp increase in communication via images (rather than text)" (Voorveld, 2019, p. 20); yet, academic storytelling research is still mostly based on complex narrative plots that are cohesively presented by external storytellers. Extending these findings to image-based advertising is problematic because images cannot easily convey a temporal sequence that is crucial for traditional modes of brand storytelling. The shift towards image-centric advertising thus necessitates a better understanding of how marketers can create and select images that prompt consumers to self-generate stories in their own minds (Grigsby *et al.*, 2023; Lim and Childs, 2020), in ways that align with desired brand meanings (Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014; Scholz, 2025).

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Prior research on *visual storytelling* has predominantly adopted consumer-response (e.g. Grigsby *et al.*, 2023; Lim and Childs, 2020; Nikulina *et al.*, 2024) and advertising-as-text perspectives (e.g. Freire, 2014; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Rokka and Canniford, 2016) which examine, respectively, what conditions prompt consumers to narratively process images and how image-based advertisements convey broader meanings and value systems (see Web Appendix 1). While these perspectives provide valuable insights, guidance on how marketers could steer consumers' self-generated stories into directions that enable brands to differentiate themselves from competitors, to create *specific* stories in consumers' minds, has been mostly missing thus far.

In this article, we take an advertising-production perspective (Aimé, 2023; Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014), rather than a consumer-response or advertising-as-text perspective, to explore how marketers can tell differentiating brand stories through still images. More specifically, our goal is to examine the role of archetypes in visual storytelling and how marketers can translate brand stories into single-image content through consistently enacting a suitable archetype. Archetypes are learnt building blocks of culture (Mark and Pearson, 2001) that are stored in consumers' memory and that can be activated by branded content (Faber and Mayer, 2009). Prior research has shown that marketers can use archetypes to differentiate their brands from competitors (Merlo *et al.*, 2023) and align consumers' self-generated stories with desired brand meanings (Megehee and Spake, 2012; Woodside *et al.*, 2008). However, the processes through which plot-based brand stories get translated into archetypal visual content are little understood. Thus, this research integrates neo-archetypal theory (Faber and Mayer, 2009) with practice theory (Schatzki, 2002) to explore (a) at an outcome level whether plot-based brand stories can be cohesively and consistently expressed through single-image content through enacting a matching archetype and (b) at a process level how managers organize their visual storytelling practices to consistently articulate a suitable archetype.

We use multiple methods and datasets to examine these questions. We collect all grid-based Instagram posts of seven wine brands for the duration of one year (1,244 posts) and perform a critical visual analysis (Schroeder, 2008) to identify dominant character archetypes expressed through these images. Furthermore, we conduct 10 depth interviews with representatives of each brand and three professional storytellers to examine how managers select images to tell their stories. Together with analysing the web pages of the seven focal brands, these data enable us to identify differences in how well brands enact archetypes in their visual storytelling (i.e. outcome level) and to examine what managerial actions and thought patterns drive variations in archetype consistency (i.e. process level).

Findings demonstrate that archetypes provide a shared understanding (Schatzki, 2002; Welch and Warde, 2016) that can align meanings between plot-based brand stories and visual content. Similar to prior studies (Merlo *et al.*, 2023; Xara-Brasil *et al.*, 2018), we find that some brands are more consistent than others in their archetypal enactments. Yet, our study moves beyond existing work as we detail how these differences are produced by competing teleoaffective structures (Schatzki, 2002) that either promote or inhibit alignments of archetypal meanings. We discuss how these findings contribute to the literatures on visual storytelling (e.g. Nikulina *et al.*, 2024; Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) and archetypal marketing (e.g. Woodside *et al.*, 2008). Specifically, this study advances understandings of:

- the role of archetypes in visual storytelling (i.e. archetypes can express differentiated and nuanced brand meanings, but they must be enrolled in storytelling practices to affect how marketers act and what makes sense for them to do); and
- how a visual mix is articulated in marketing practice (i.e. how competing goals can be balanced, and what dangers are posed by overly emphasizing customer engagement metrics).

2. Visual storytelling: How to steer consumers' self-generated narratives?

Traditional storytelling research, which has been developed against a backdrop of long-form narratives that are told through text or video, typically assumes the presence of an external storyteller who cohesively presents sequential narratives to a story receiver (e.g. van Laer *et al.*, 2014; Woodside *et al.*, 2008). In this traditional view, externally-presented sequential narratives establish chronology and causality, which in turn enable receivers to consume the story. Chronology refers to the internal temporality of a story (Stern, 1994), which is often organized into a beginning, middle and end (Green and Brock, 2000). Causality refers to how different story elements are related to one another, which enables story receivers to understand why events happen and story characters evolve (Stern, 1994).

Still images, on the other hand, are moments frozen in time without sequential narratives for establishing chronology and causality. Hence, "much of the research on narrative transportation cannot be extended to more contemporary picture-based advertising" (Grigsby *et al.*, 2023, p. 595), or at least not straightforwardly. This realization gave rise to an emerging stream on *visual storytelling research* which has detailed conditions under which consumers spontaneously identify and transport into *visual narratives* that are embedded within still images (Freire, 2014; Nikulina *et al.*, 2024; Phillips and McQuarrie, 2010). See Figure 1 for a visualization of how our study is situated within the visual storytelling literature, and Web Appendix 1 for a summary of visual storytelling and related research.

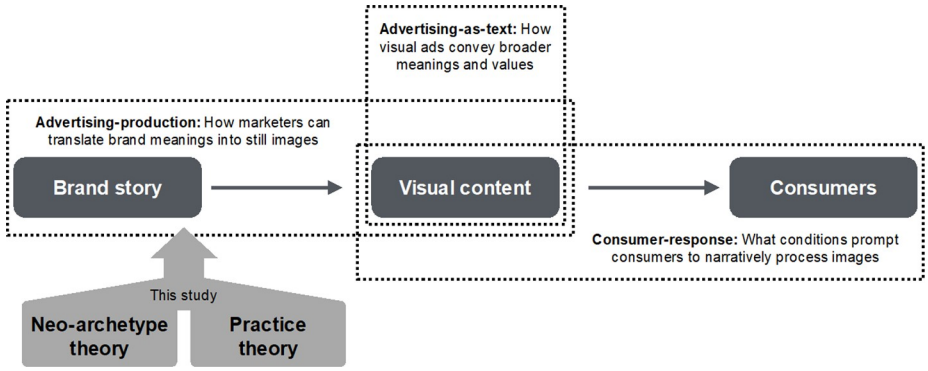
The remainder of this section reviews three perspectives present in this literature, arguing that existing visual storytelling research has not yet sufficiently examined the *processes* (e.g. actions and thought patterns; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) through which decision-makers create and select images to express *specific* brand stories consistently over time on social media.

2.1 Consumer-response and advertising-as-text perspectives: lacking specificity in what stories consumers may self-generate

Visual storytelling research often takes a consumer-response perspective that examines under what conditions consumers are likely to engage in narrative processing and self-generate stories in their own heads. This research generally points to the importance

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Figure 1 Situating this study within the visual storytelling literature



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of depicting a scene in which human characters, animals or anthropomorphized products are situated and act within a particular context (Nikulina *et al.*, 2024). Images that imply movement, for example, prompt consumers to spontaneously construct chronological and causal narratives (Grigsby *et al.*, 2023), but only when characters are shown within a context rather than against a white background (Lim and Childs, 2020). Other contextual elements such as ambiguity, mysteriousness, complexity, grotesque elements and first-person perspectives furthermore aide spontaneous generation of visual narratives (Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Nikulina *et al.*, 2024; Phillips and McQuarrie, 2010). While this perspective identifies many visual elements that trigger narrative processing of images, it does not provide any guidance on how consumers' self-generated visual narratives can be shaped to express specific meanings that align with plot-based brand stories.

Other research has adopted an advertising-as-text perspective to examine how image-based advertisements convey meanings and cultural value systems. This research has identified visual codes that express broader category-level values, such as luxury (Freire, 2014; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Rokka and Canniford, 2016). Related research has examined how print ads shape meaning systems around general concepts such as nature (Scholz, 2012) or gender identity (Schroeder and Borgerson, 1998; Schroeder and Zwick, 2004), and how the interplay between visual and textual elements within a print ad constructs a dramatic narrative consumers can decode in their consumption of the advertising text (Stern and Schroeder, 1994). This type of research details how image-based advertisements express cultural meanings. Yet, it is mostly focused on identifying visual codes that embody generic category values (e.g. luxury) or broad cultural concepts (e.g. masculinity, nature), rather than examining on a brand-level what cultural building blocks visually express more specific stories that could differentiate brands from their competitors (Woodside *et al.*, 2008).

In sum, the advertising-as-text and consumer-response perspectives demonstrate that images can carry narrative meanings and can induce spontaneous generation of visual narratives in consumers' minds. Yet, these perspectives provide insufficient guidance to marketers because they focus on identifying general characteristics that trigger transportation or outlining visual codes that express merely broader cultural or category-level meanings.

Marketers' goal, however, is not to tell *any* story or a *generic* story, but a *specific* story. Brand managers, advertising agencies, and content creators need to know how to select and arrange *particular types* of characters, contexts, implied movements, and visual codes to induce self-generated narratives in alignment with the *specific* strategic directions and stories of their brands (Phillips *et al.*, 2014). For example, communicating symbolic meanings of luxury (Freire, 2014; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019) is important for a brand like Dolce & Gabbana but not sufficient, as Dolce & Gabbana also needs to differentiate itself from other luxury houses (Phillips and McQuarrie, 2010). How managers can improve specificity in their visual storytelling has remained relatively unexplored within these two perspectives.

2.2 Advertising-production perspective: How are complex brand stories translated into still images?

Another shortcoming of the first two perspectives is that they provide no insights into the *processes* of how brand meanings and stories are translated into still images (Pecot *et al.*, 2022). Very few studies have adopted an advertising-production perspective. Examining the managerial production of brand stories more broadly, Aimé (2023) finds that managers interpret and perform brand storytelling differently, according to their personality and understanding of the brand. The author briefly notes that this can lead to advertising imagery that is inconsistent and ill-aligned with brand meanings and calls for coordinating visuals across channels. However, no insights are offered into how brand meanings can be cohesively and consistently translated into visual content. Studies that combine in-depth visual analysis of advertising materials with expert interviews – to illuminate how marketing professionals and creatives identify, select and arrange visual codes to tell stories in a visual format – are especially rare. Two studies examine how various visual elements such as text, illustrations, logos, ornaments and photography are assembled within the context of print advertising campaigns: Pecot *et al.* (2022) found that art directors and graphic designers see their main task as assembling a unique visual mix, or a "particular articulation of visual codes that intend to translate the brand positioning" (p. 122) into a recognizable and differentiated visual expression. Similarly, Phillips *et al.* (2014) show that art directors' objective is to combine various visual elements into a "holistic look and feel and style" (p. 324) of a brand that is

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consistent in terms of how the visual elements express the brand strategy, how various visual elements combine into the overall visual expression and how brand visuals remain similar and recognizable over time.

While existing articles thus emphasize the need to mix various visual elements, they do not provide sufficient insights into how this mixing is achieved in marketing practice. In particular, how brand representatives actually translate brand meanings into visual content through consistently assembling suitable visual codes has remained largely unexplored. Prior research merely points out that marketing professionals value differentiation and consistency (Aimé, 2023; Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) but does not examine the managerial actions and thought patterns through which these goals can be accomplished. Detailing these processes becomes particularly important within contemporary social media marketing environments, due to the availability of real-time metrics. Whereas the creation of print ad campaigns unfolds somewhat separately from day-to-day marketing (Phillips *et al.*, 2014), content creation in social media environments is an ongoing activity that is heavily informed by customer-response metrics and the instant feedback they provide on individual posts (Bartoloni and Ancillai, 2024). Easy access to social media metrics represents additional external forces that likely impact the formulation of the visual mix (Pecot *et al.*, 2022); however, how these unique conditions impact translations of brand story plots into visual content have remained unexplored thus far.

3. The role of archetypes in visual storytelling practices

The previous section has outlined how existing research on visual storytelling has been relatively mute regarding the *processes* through which managers post images on social media to express *specific* brand stories consistently over time. The current section integrates neo-archetypal theory (Faber and Mayer, 2009) with practice theory (Schatzki, 2002) to jointly address both of these gaps. As we explain in more detail below, archetypes offer a rich repertoire of cultural building blocks that can improve specificity in visual storytelling. However, existing archetype research also provides no detailed analysis of the processes through which archetypes are visually articulated in marketing practice. We therefore leverage practice theory, specifically its concepts of "general understandings" and "teleoaffective structures" (Schatzki, 2002; Welch and Warde, 2016), to examine the role of archetypes in visual storytelling practices.

3.1 Archetypes as cultural building blocks for visual storytelling

The concept of archetypes was originally proposed by Carl Jung (1968), who described archetypes as personifications of universal behavioural patterns which arise from primordial mythological stories located in a collective unconsciousness. Contemporary approaches align Jung's theory with cognitive psychology to conceptualize archetypes as building blocks of culture which people learn through cultural immersion and which they use to understand the world around them (Mark and Pearson, 2001; Woodside *et al.*, 2008). Faber and Mayer (2009) presented five key characteristics of this neo-archetypal theory: Archetypes are (a) story characters that (b)people have stored in their memory as mental models, similar to self- and other-schemata, and that (c) are capable of eliciting intense emotional responses when encountered. In line with the processing of other mental models, archetypes (d) operate at an automatic level and can be activated non-consciously. Finally, archetypes are (e) culturally enduring and percolate widely within a culture's literary, folkloric, and artistic traditions. As archetypes are continuously reproduced by cultural industries and widely accessible within high-brow and popular culture, people implicitly recognize archetypes without formal training.

With regards to the first characteristic, archetypes are commonly thought of as prototypical personas that appear as discrete story characters within a story plot (Faber and Mayer, 2009; Merlo *et al.*, 2023). Multiple authors have proposed frameworks that organize and describe archetypes into 12 to 13 main categories (Campbell 1949 / 2004; McAdams, 1993). Mark and Pearson (2001; see Web Appendix 2) provided one of the most extensive and influential treatments that underlies much archetype research published in psychology (Faber and Mayer, 2009) and marketing (Ganassali and Matysiewicz, 2020; Merlo *et al.*, 2023; Xara-Brasil *et al.*, 2018). While the descriptors in Web Appendix 2 may suggest that archetypes must be presented through rich sequential narratives, archetypes can also manifest thematically when being depicted in images, paintings, sculptures or even brand logos (Faber and Mayer, 2009).

The remaining four key characteristics of neo-archetypal theory indicate that archetypes, much like other cognitive schemata, can be activated through branded content and consequently drive consumers' reactions to the brand. Woodside and colleagues' (2008) consumer storytelling theory is a particularly influential framework for integrating archetypes with marketing communications: Brands, products, and advertisements can serve as "props or anthropomorphic actors in stories (that consumers) report about themselves and others" (p. 97). Brands that convey a specific archetype enable consumers to mentally and/or physically enact the same archetype. And by aligning themselves with these powerful archetypal myths, consumers – as protagonists in the stories they tell – can construct and communicate desired identities such as being a "hero, outlaw, magician or some other archetypal form" (Woodside *et al.*, 2008, p. 100).

While archetypes thus help brands shape consumer-generated stories in ways that align with their own *specific* brand meanings (Faber and Mayer, 2009; Ganassali and Matysiewicz, 2020; Mark and Pearson, 2001), prior research has not yet detailed the *processes* through which brands become carriers of archetypal meanings and how marketers consistently enact a suitable archetype across multiple pieces of single-image content. Woodside *et al.* (2008), for example, base their discussion of how brands enable consumers' archetype enactments on the template of classical drama productions, complete with "plot lines scripted by brand controllers" (p. 107) that establish chronology and causality in sequential (rather than visual) narratives. They further propose "that the classical drama productions by marketers reflect one or a few archetypes" (p. 113); yet it remains unclear through what actions and thought patterns brands achieve cohesive and consistent archetype articulations in their image-based content. Considering the imperative for consistency

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in marketing communications (Mark and Pearson, 2001; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) and findings that brands often struggle to create consistent archetypal enactments (Merlo *et al.*, 2023; Xara-Brasil *et al.*, 2018), generating insights into these processes is particularly important.

3.2 Archetypes as "general understandings" that shape practice performances

Practice theory highlights the doings and sayings that are involved in the production of social life, including marketing communications (Skålén *et al.*, 2023). Given its focus on how marketing professionals act based on what is practically intelligible (Schatzki, 2002) to them, or what makes sense for them to do, practice theory offers a suitable framework for examining the role of archetypes in visual storytelling.

Practices can be defined as a routinized way in which "objects are handled, subjects are treated, things are described and the world is understood" (Reckwitz, 2002, p. 250) or as an organized nexus of doings and sayings that are routinely performed (Schatzki, 2002). Skålén and colleagues (2023) synthesized these views and define practices as "organized activities routinely carried out by a group of people", likening practices to "shared templates" that indicate "how activities are, can and should be carried out" (p. 188). A core tenet of practice theory is the interdependence between doings and sayings, material artefacts and cultural meanings (Schatzki, 2005; Scholz, 2021). Following this tripartite typology, we conceptualize the practice of visual storytelling as the managerial *actions and thought patterns* (i.e. doings and sayings) deployed to create and post *visual content* (i.e. materialities) that expresses strategically relevant *brand stories and narratives* (i.e. meanings). While we recognize that practices are often nested within each other, we conceptualize visual storytelling at this particular level to highlight its core challenge: How are brand meanings, which are explicitly and/or implicitly formulated in narrative form, translated into visual content that lacks sequential narratives?

Unlike routines, practices are not carried out exactly the same way every time (Skålén *et al.*, 2023). Practice performances vary due to differences in people's training or how the mind organizes a set of doings and sayings as a practice (Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001,Schatzki, 2005). The ways in which individuals perform practices, or what makes sense to them to do next at any moment in time during practice performances (i.e. practical intelligibility; Schatzki, 2002), are organized by three phenomena: a set of rules, a teleoaffective structure and a shared pool of understandings (Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001; Schatzki, 2005; Schau *et al.*, 2009). Rules refer to explicit and normative directives that regulate practices. Within the context of visual storytelling, these would be regulations by social media platforms that may forbid the use of certain visuals (e.g. full nudity). Because such rules affect all marketers equally, they are less important for understanding how brands can best express their brand stories in visual form.

Teleoaffective structure refers to the acceptable or correct goals, tasks to be carried out to reach these goals, beliefs about which tasks should be carried out, as well as the emotions, moods and normative expectations associated with these goals and tasks. In short, the teleoaffective structure provides a motivational and normative framework for action. There can be a range of acceptable teleoaffective structures that may conflict with one another (Schatzki, 2005). For the practice of visual storytelling, one teleoaffective structure would be to maximize consistency between brand narratives and individual pieces of visual content; yet the materialities of social media networks (e.g. easily accessible metrics) may highlight other correct ends, such as the maximization of customer engagement.

Finally, a pool of understanding refers to practical know-how, skills, abilities and knowledge that are required to perform practices competently (Schatzki, 2005). In the context of visual storytelling, this may include practically knowing how to post images on social media but also tacitly knowing what makes for a "good" image. The latter requires practitioners to draw on "general understandings" (Schatzki, 2002) which make intelligible that "people and things [bear] such and such meanings and not others" (i.e. institution of meaning; Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001, p. 55). Welch and Warde (2016) described general understandings as "fundamental, culturally structuring concepts" (p. 183), "ideational elements" (p. 184), and "widely shared, pre-reflexive, background understandings" (p. 190) that are "sedimented in cognitive and affective dispositions and activated and transmitted by discursive, symbolic and material elements of popular and consumer culture" (p. 194). Thus, in our interpretation, archetypes are one particular kind of "general understandings" that shape people's practice performances through "conditioning practical intelligibility" (Welch and Warde, 2016, p. 187). Archetypes, therefore, can explain why someone "x-Ed. instead of y-Ed." (Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001, p. 59) in their practice performances.

More plainly, our integration of practice theory with archetypes suggest that archetypes provide marketing professionals with pre-reflexive background understandings that enable them to discern "good" from "bad" content, within the context of their brands. However, how archetypal general understandings become enrolled into practice performances remains an open empirical question. The current research therefore explores the following two questions:

RQ1. Can archetypes facilitate the translation of specific plot-based brand stories into still images?

RQ2. How can managers select single-image content to create cohesive and consistent articulations of archetypes over time?

In other words, we examine the role of archetypes for visual storytelling at two levels: Firstly, at an outcome-level by comparing brands' richer text-based narratives with the archetypal distribution in their visual communications, and next at a process-level by examining what managerial actions and thought patterns produce more consistent archetype enactments in their visual storytelling practices.

4. Methodology

We explore these research questions through a critical visual analysis (Schroeder, 2008; Schroeder and Borgerson, 1998) of Instagram content and an interpretative phenomenological analysis of in-depth interviews with social media managers

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(Javornik *et al.*, 2021; Phillips *et al.*, 2014). The critical visual analysis enables us to assess the role of archetypes at the outcome-level and sets up our interpretative analysis of the processes that drive these outcomes. One unique strength of this approach is that we combine an analysis of brand's visual communications with the actions and thought patterns of the people who were directly responsible for creating it. This allows us to map how the doings and sayings, materialities and meanings that constitute visual storytelling practices are assembled in everyday marketing activities.

Critical visual analysis is an interpretivist and semiotic approach to examine how images produce and reflect meanings (Freire, 2014; Rokka and Canniford, 2016; Schroeder and Zwick, 2004). Building on the seminal work of Scott (1994), Stern and Schroeder (1994) and McQuarrie and Mick (2003), and informed by art criticism, (art) history and cultural studies (Scholz, 2012; Schroeder and Borgerson, 1998; Stern and Schroeder, 1994), critical visual analysis emphasizes that images are not merely accurate visual records of the real world. Rather, images are "symbolic artefacts constructed from the conventions of a particular culture" (Scott, 1994, p. 252). Critical visual analysis, thus, not only pays attention to *what* is pictured, but also (and especially) to *how* something is depicted. The style of visual depictions, which arises from the semiotic relationships between various elements in the composition (Scott, 1994; Schroeder and Borgerson, 1998; Stern and Schroeder, 1994), is of foremost importance in this approach because it permits the exploration (e.g. Scholz, 2012; Schroeder and Zwick, 2004) and production (e.g. Freire, 2014) of multilayered meanings embedded within images.

This semiotic approach differentiates critical visual analysis from more typical content analyses performed on images (e.g. Filieri *et al.*, 2021; Pecot *et al.*, 2022). As Scott (1994) explained, traditional visual content analyses operate on the assumption that images reflect the real world and therefore break down images into individual components that can be objectively assessed and independently categorized. However, this "simple count" assumes that "the meaning of a pictorial text can be derived simply by recording *what* is pictured, irrespective of *how* it is pictured or what might have been *intended* by the picturing" (Scott, 1994, p. 250). In other words, traditional visual content analyses are blind to how the internal composition and external cultural conventions determine what overarching meanings are portrayed. For example, the finding that "flowers" are the most common visual element (Filieri *et al.*, 2021), carries no information about the composition and style in which these flowers are depicted, or for what rhetorical purpose. A bouquet of spring flowers held by a freshly married couple conveys very different meanings than a wreath of white roses placed at a funeral service, and a bush of flowers photographed outdoors carries different meanings depending on whether the surrounding landscape is depictured as harmonic or threatening (Scholz, 2012). Critical visual analysis, on the other hand, is sensitized to the semiotic relationships that produce nuanced meanings. Once identified, these overarching meanings can then be related to archetypal categories to enable aggregation, comparison and evaluation across a large corpus of data in a following step.

4.1 Data sampling procedures

Our study uses Instagram content of seven wine brands and ten managerial in-depth interviews as its two main datasets. We selected interviewees (see Table 1) based on our professional network, intermixing representatives of smaller and larger wine brands with professional social media storytellers, to increase variance within the dataset. Once we had an interview with a brand representative scheduled, we began analysing the visual data of this wine brand to familiarize ourselves with their visual content and prepare interview cues. The company websites for each of the seven focal brands serve as a supplemental third

Table 1 List of expert interviews

Company	Role	Education	Professional experience
Brand A	Marketing manager	Bachelor's degree in marketing and communication	10 years: marketing and wine industry
Brand B	General manager	Diploma in winery and viticulture technician	30 years: wine industry
Brand C	Social media manager	Bachelor's degree in business and public relations	1 year: social media and event coordinator
Brand D	Brand manager	Bachelor's degree in marketing	8 years: social media marketing
Brand X	Winery owner	MBA in wine marketing	10 years: banking and wine industry
Brand Y	Social media manager	Bachelor's degree in marketing	22 years: wine industry, public relations, social media
Brand Z	Head winemaker	Bachelor's degree in oenology and viticulture	30+ years: wine industry
Storyteller A	Social media storyteller	Bachelor's degree in environmental policy and urban planning; sommelier certification	5 years: urban planning; three years: wine industry and social media
Storyteller B	Social media storyteller	Bachelor's degree in marketing; sommelier certification	15 years: restaurant sommelier; 10 years: social media storytelling
Storyteller C	Social media storyteller	Bachelor's degree in journalism and broadcasting	15 years: television reporter; two years: social media storytelling

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data set. We examine the websites to discern brands' plot-based brand stories and for general background information.

We took screenshots of all individual Instagram posts for each of the seven brands, going back in time for one year. This yielded 1,244 posts, presenting a data corpus similar in size (Gurzki *et al.*, 2019) or about two-and-a-half times larger than what has been previously analysed in similar studies (Filieri *et al.*, 2021; Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Rokka and Canniford, 2016; Scholz, 2012). What Instagram considers "videos" technically account for 11% of posts; however, the majority of these are animated images or very short scenes, rather than long-form narratives. To recognize the potential archetypal content embedded in these posts, we include this material and conduct our analysis based on the first 10 s of runtime, or less.

Our second main data set comprises in-depth interviews with representatives of each of the seven focal brands, plus three interviews with social media storytellers who manage the accounts of several brands and/or micro-blog about wine on Instagram. We interviewed brand representatives to better understand how they approach visual storytelling and content selection on Instagram. Thus, the guide for our semi-structured interviews focused on informants' professional backgrounds, brand story descriptions, metrics used, target markets and most importantly, visual storytelling and content marketing strategies. Previewing brands' Instagram accounts and webpages informed our open-ended conversations and helped us identify probes for further discussion (Phillips *et al.*, 2014). For example, we would ask interviewees to discuss certain posts, their elements, how they relate to the brand story, and why and how these images were selected. We adapted this approach for social media storytellers with a more general focus on brand storytelling strategies on Instagram. Interviews lasted, on average, one hour and were audio recorded and transcribed.

4.2 Analysis of visual and interview data

Our first step was to identify a dominant archetype for each post in our Instagram dataset via a critical visual analysis (Schroeder, 2008). We developed an analytical template (see Web Appendix 3) to guide our analysis of formal and thematic elements within the images by adapting prior templates (Schroeder and Borgerson, 1998) with insights from related research (Freire, 2014; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Phillips and McQuarrie, 2010; Scholz, 2012; Scott, 1994; Stern and Schroeder, 1994). This template enables us to assign images to corresponding archetypes through a bottom-up semiotic analysis of their formal (e.g. genre, lines and shapes, composition, colour, perspective) and thematic elements (e.g. subject matter, characters, activities, setting). A close reading of the 12 archetypes (Mark and Pearson, 2001) facilitated this process.

The first and third author jointly performed three consecutive rounds of analysis during which we refined our interpretations through weekly research meetings and email discussions (Gurzki *et al.*, 2019). We used critical visual analysis techniques of comparing and contrasting (Schroeder, 2008), for example by comparing similar motifs and compositions within and across brands, and interpretating the visual text in relation to the characteristics of archetypes. Even though it is possible for an image to align with several archetypes, we assigned each post one archetype of (Mark and Pearson, 2001) classification system that we deemed most dominant. Post for which no archetype was discernible (e.g. posts that showed wine bottles against a plain backdrop) were coded as non-archetype. Those non-archetype images do not depict a character within a context, which has been found necessary for narrative transportation to occur (Grigsby *et al.*, 2023; Lim and Childs, 2020). The third round of assigning archetypes resulted in only a few changes to our coding, which prompted us to end this part of our analysis and to aggregate our archetypal readings into archetype distributions for each brand.

At this stage, we noted that some brands in our dataset were much more consistently articulated than others, showing larger percentages of their leading archetype and fewer non-archetype posts (see Table 2). This emergent finding guides our interpretative analysis of the interview data, which examines what could account for the differences in archetype distribution. The first and third author first performed open coding for each interview to uncover interviewees' actions and mindset while creating and selecting content. As our analysis progressed, we performed axial coding (Strauss and Corbin, 1998) to examine similarities between interviews as well as between the interviews and brands' Instagram accounts.

5. Findings

5.1 The outcomes of visual storytelling: archetypes align meanings across text modalities

In this section, we examine how archetypes provide shared understandings that can align meanings between complex brand story narratives and visual content. We first illustrate how multiple elements within a visual arrangement semiotically express archetypal meanings and then aggregate individual archetypal readings into an archetype distribution for each brand (section 5.1.1). This archetypal analysis enables us to analyse the outcome of brands' visual storytelling practices; specifically, how cohesively (section 5.1.2) and consistently (section 5.1.3) brands translate plot-based brand stories into their visual content.

5.1.1 Archetypal meanings semiotically emerge: illustration and aggregation

Plate 1 presents six images of Brand A that we coded as enacting either the "caregiver" (panels 1–3) or "creator" archetype (panels 4–6). We coded image number 1 as "caregiver" because several visual elements coalesce into a comforting atmosphere and convey meanings of self-care and self-nurture: A woman is wrapped in a warming blanket while the sun is casting her in soft and warm light. She sits in an informal setting; at a small woven side-table while holding a stemless wine glass. The woman seems to be taking a break, nurturing herself with some fresh grapes, and reading a book. By contrast, the more industrial scene in panel 4 enacts the "creator" archetype by showing someone who is in the process of winemaking. Hoses are scattered across a concrete floor in a tall industrial building and the winemaker operates some gauges and dials on large stainless steel wine tanks. Interacting with production facilities while displaying an immense focus and passion aligns with core meanings of the "creator"

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Table 2 Brand stories and archetypal analysis

Brand	Plot-based brand story and abstraction into archetype (based on web page & interviews; suitable archetypes in *italics*)	Archetype distribution (largest percentage in *italics*)	Cohesiveness: How closely do archetypes match brand story	Consistency of lead AT
Consistently articulated brands				
Brand A	A family story about "three generations actively involved" in the winery and that positions the wine as "a product of our family's passion" *[creator]*. the family is "proud to . . . share the fruits of our labor" and considers "each person that enjoys a glass of [brand A] wine to be a part of our family" *[caregiver]*	*Lead: 48% Caregiver* Follow-up: 8% Creator Follow-up: 8% Lover All other: 12% Non-archetype: 18% COVID: 5%	*Very cohesive:* Lead archetype and follow-up archetype match dominant themes in the plot-based brand story	ATC = 6.0 ATW = 2.7
Brand B	A winery "crafting honest, low-intervention wine . . . that reflect their individuality as artifacts of the niagara region" *[creator]*. they utilize "practices that create a healthy soil ecology" *[sage]* to "create expressive and structured wines" *[creator]*, and winemakers "attempt to learn how the varying seasonal conditions impact the distinct flavors, textures and focus" of the wines *[sage]*	*Lead: 52% Innocent* Follow up: 16% Creator Follow up: 5% Caregiver All other: 8% Non-archetype: 15% COVID: 5%	*Cohesive:* First follow-up archetype matches one (albeit not clearly dominant) theme in the plot-based brand story	ATC = 3.3 ATW = 3.5
Brand C	Brand story is focused on showing how a deep understanding of the favorable growing conditions at the estate *[sage]* yields high quality wine *[creator]*: situated in "the most abundant and fertile lands" *[innocent]*, "flat topography allows for maximum sun exposure" *[sage]*, and "many creeks that provide natural drainage ideal for premium grape growing" *[sage]*	*Lead: 48% Caregiver* Follow up:13% Innocent Follow up: 13% Jester All other: 6% Non-archetype: 10% COVID: 10%	*Less cohesive:* Brand story sometimes connects to the innocent archetype; however, this is a peripheral theme as the natural conditions are typically cast as a mystery to be analyzed and understood *[sage]* in the service of production quality *[creator]*	ATC = 3.7 ATW = 4.8
Brand D	An environmentally conscious brand who define themselves as "a disorderly mob of outcasts, believers, and dreamers who are determined to create real change" *[outlaw]*. they "make wine for people like you . . . who love to live, dream and drink great wine without borders or boundaries" and aim to be non-pretentious *[regular guy/gal]*	*Lead: 47% Reg. Guy/Gal* Follow up: 16% Caregiver Follow up: 15% Innocent All other: 15% Non-archetype: 6% COVID: 9%	*Cohesive:* Lead archetype matches a dominant theme in brand story, but outlaw theme is rarely represented through visual content	ATC = 2.9 ATW = 7.8
Ambiguously articulated brands				
Brand X	Story is focused on the husband-and-wife founders who made their "dream" of owning a "small-scale, artisanal" winery "a reality" *[innocent]*. emphasizes bringing out the terroir by "finding small, unique plots of land . . . and putting them in bottle" *[magician/creator]*, "minimal intervention" *[creator/innocent]*, and "stripping away all the fancy buildings and high-tech equipment" *[innocent]*	Lead: 21% Innocent Follow up: 18% Creator Follow up: 8% Caregiver All other: 14% *Non-archetype: 36%* COVID: 4%	*Very cohesive:* Lead archetype and follow-up archetype match dominant themes in the plot-based brand story	ATC = 1.2 ATW = 0.6
Brand Y	An environmentally conscious brand that "unites tradition and science to serve the winemaker's art" *[creator]* and practices "winemaking steeped in tradition that blends with innovation and ingenuity" *[creator]*. two winemakers are introduced to have "unwavering commitment to care and quality", a "spirit of innovation", and "passion for experimentation" *[creator]*	Lead: 25% Magician Follow up: 10% Innocent Follow up: 6% Creator All other: 10% *Non-archetype: 41%* COVID: 8%	*Less cohesive:* Second follow-up archetype matches the dominant theme in the plot-based story	ATC = 2.5 ATW = 0.6

(***continued***)

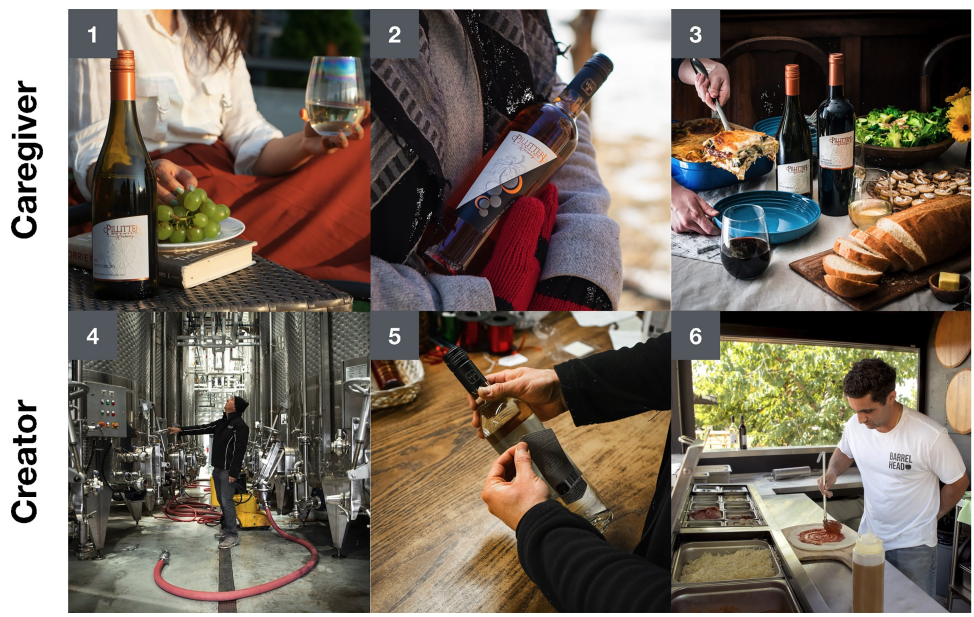
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Table 2

Brand	Plot-based brand story and abstraction into archetype (based on web page & interviews; suitable archetypes in *italics*)	Archetype distribution (largest percentage in *italics*)	Cohesiveness: How closely do archetypes match brand story	Consistency of lead AT
Brand Z	A picturesque winery and restaurant that is steeped in history: Their "roots in this very unique and beloved place" *[innocent]*. the "original homestead" now "provides a warm, welcoming place to greet and care for our guests" *[caregiver]*. buildings are preserved even as the winery expands or suffers from fire, and. the idyllic and pastoral scenery promises to capture "your heart and your imagination" *[innocent]*	Lead: 21% Caregiver Follow up: 15% Sage Follow up: 13% Innocent All other: 21% *Non-archetype: 30%* COVID: 2%	*Very cohesive:* Lead archetype and second follow-up archetype match dominant themes in the plot-based brand story	ATC = 1.4 ATW = 0.7

Note(s): Archetype consistency (ATC) metric is calculated by dividing lead AT by first follow-up. Archetype weight (ATW) metric is calculated by dividing lead AT by non-archetype
Source(s): The authors

Plate 1 Lead and follow-up archetypes of Brand A



Source: Pilliteri Estates Winery (publicly available Instagram posts)

archetype, such as meticulously creating something of special and enduring value.

The next two pairs in Plate 1 further illustrate how archetypal meanings are not determined by any single indicator but emerge from the semiotic relationships between multiple visual elements: Panels 2 and 5 both depict someone holding a wine bottle. Yet, simply counting these images as "people holding wine bottles", as would be the case for conventional visual content analyses (e.g. Filieri *et al.*, 2021), does not uncover the differential meanings that are conveyed. An archetypal reading emphasizes how the cradling in panel 2 casts the bottle as fragile, like a newborn baby, supported by other visual elements (e.g. knitted mittens, a thick coat, a scarf, a cold winter landscape) that emphasize the harshness of the world. The overall composition hence conveys meanings of nurturing and protection from harm, which are characteristic of the "caregiver" archetype. In panel 5, conversely, the bottle is held in ways that cast it as a precious product worked on by artisanal hands. Red gift ribbons in the background furthermore emphasize how this bottle is special and something that can be gifted. The semiotic relationships between the bottle, applying a label by hand and gift wrapping coalesce into a portrayal of artisanal production and the creation of something with enduring value, as expressed by the "creator" archetype. Likewise, panels 3 and 6 both portray the act of serving or producing a meal; yet differences in visual elements (e.g. a

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family style kitchen table versus an industrial kitchen) create divergent meanings. Hence, despite the many similarities that could be identified (e.g. both images contain Italian food), the semiotic relationships that unfold across multiple visual elements convey two different archetypal meaning systems.

Aggregating our archetypal readings across all images yields the archetype distribution for each brand. For example, we identify "caregiver" as Brand A's lead archetype, representing 48% of total content. The "creator" and "lover" emerged as two follow-up archetypes, with 8% of posts each. Posts that did not convey any clear archetype accounted for 18% of Brand's A content. We repeated the same archetypal analysis for all other brands in our data set and present archetypal distributions in the centre column of Table 2. These aggregate numbers enable us to examine cohesiveness and consistency of brands' visual content via the next two sub-sections.

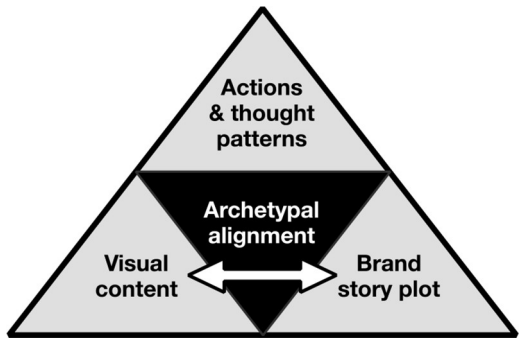
5.1.2 Cohesiveness: archetypes institute and align meanings across text modalities

In addition to above's archetypal analysis of *visual* content, we also abstract brands' *plot-based narratives* into archetypes to evaluate how cohesively brand stories are aligned across different text modalities. Table 2 summarizes brands' plot-based stories (sourced from online texts, online long-form videos, and expert interviews), archetype distributions and assessments of how cohesively dominant archetypes express plot-based narratives. For example, Brand A's story plot connects to the "creator" archetype because being "proud to be able to share the fruits of our labor" expresses the desire to produce material objects of high quality and integrity that are of enduring value. Brand A furthermore expresses elements of the "caregiver" archetype in its plot-based story when it invites patrons "to be part of our family", thus, demonstrating a desire for providing comfort, making a difference for someone else and being empathetic and welcoming (Mark and Pearson, 2001).

Overall, we find brands' dominant visual content to be mostly aligned with plot-based narratives: Returning to the prior example, the "caregiver" and "creator" themes of Brand A's story plot match the lead and follow-up archetypes that emerged from our archetypal analysis of its visual content. Thus, even though visual compositions do not always directly re-enact concrete story themes, as illustrated by the images depicted in Plate 1 (see above), Brand A cohesively translates the more abstract meanings of its plot-based brand story into suitable visual content. The other brands in our sample also tend to use lead and/or follow-up archetypes that match with dominant or at least supporting themes in their plot-based brand stories (see columns 2–4 in Table 2).

These findings suggests that archetypes, by virtue of being cultural building blocks people intuitively use to make sense of the world (Ganassali and Matysiewicz, 2020; Woodside *et al.*, 2008), provide shared general understandings (Schatzki, 2002; Welch and Warde, 2016) that organize storytelling practices across different text modalities (see black triangle and white arrow in Figure 2). A core requirement for successful practice performances is that practitioners generally understand what things are. In Schatzki's (2001) words, this "institution of meaning [. . .] establishes, as a matter of intelligibility, [. . .] that something is a particular object or event and not another, that someone's identity is such and such and not this and that, in general, that the meanings and identities borne by the components of a particular arrangement are a, b, and c and not x, y, and z" (p. 55, emphasis added). By instituting meanings, archetypes enable managers to understand what arrangements of visual elements suitably express a brand's plot-based story (e.g. images that enact the "creator" or "caregiver" archetypes for Brand A; the "a" and "b" in Schatzki's terms), and what visual arrangements would be ill-aligned with desired brand meanings (e.g. images that enact the "hero", "outlaw" or "lover" archetype for Brand A; the "x, y and z" in Schatzki's terms).

Figure 2 Archetypes institute and align meanings across text modalities



Source: The authors

So far, we have discussed how the meanings instituted by archetypes enable cohesive alignment of brand stories across different text modalities. However, we also find that brands differ in how consistently they enact their lead archetypes through visual content (section 5.1.3), which suggest that consistent archetypal alignment may be promoted or inhibited depending on the particular actions and thought patters that are embraced by brand managers (section 5.2).

5.1.3 Consistency: consistent *versus* ambiguous archetypal gestalt

Our archetypal analysis revealed two distinct camps regarding how consistently brands are able to convey their lead archetypes: Consistently articulated brands display their lead archetypes in about half of all visual content, whereas ambiguously articulated brands have a much smaller share of lead archetypes (see Table 2 and Figure 2).

To evaluate the consistency of brands' *archetypal gestalt*, we devise two input metrics based on the distributions of lead archetype, follow-up archetype and non-archetype posts. The archetype consistency (ATC) metric divides the share of lead archetype by the share of the first follow-up to measure how clearly and consistency a brand expresses its lead archetype across all visual content. For example, Brand A is consistently articulated as a "caregiver" brand on Instagram (48% of its content, ATC = 6.0), resulting in a visually well-articulated brand that consumers can easily understand. In comparison, Brand Z also expresses the "caregiver" as its lead archetype (21% of its content) but its follow-up archetypes (the "sage" with 15% and the "innocent" with 13% of content, ATC = 1.4) represent other sizable portions of its overall communications.

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In fact, these three archetypes represent about half (49%) of Brand Z's content, whereas Brand A allocates about the same amount (48%) to only one archetype. We postulate that higher ATC scores should make it easier for consumers to recognize what particular archetypal meanings are expressed by a brand (Ganassali and Matysiewicz, 2020).

A second and related calculation, the archetype weight (ATW) metric, divides lead archetype share by non-archetype share. We postulate that consumers perceive a brand as more of a character (Mark and Pearson, 2001) the heavier archetypal information outweighs non-archetypal information. For example, a hypothetical brand that portrays itself in equal parts (30% each) as "explorer", "outlaw" and "lover" and only has 10% non-archetype posts (ATW = 3.00) should appear more intriguing and vivid to consumers than a brand that allocates 10% of it posts to each of these three archetypes and 70% to non-archetype posts (ATW = 0.14) that carry no symbolic meanings, even though scores of the ATC metric would be the same (ATC = 1.00).

The ATC and ATW metrics enable us to more clearly delineate the two camps that emerged during our analysis: Consistently articulated brands have 2.4 times stronger ATC measures and 6.4 times higher ATW measures than ambiguously articulated brands (see Figure 3 for more detailed analysis). While we do not perform statistical significance testing due to the qualitative nature of our inquiry, these results align with earlier research (Merlo *et al.*, 2023; Xara-Brasil *et al.*, 2018) which finds that some brands are more capable than others in consistently articulating their lead archetypes. In the following section, we present our process analysis to examine what managerial actions and thought patterns may produce these differences.

5.2 The process of visual storytelling: teleoaffective structures promote versus inhibit archetypal alignment

Above we have detailed the findings of our outcome-level analysis, demonstrating that archetypes enable cohesive translations of plot-based brand stories into visual content but also that brands are not equally able to achieve a consistent archetypal gestalt. In this section, we take the emergence of the consistent versus ambiguous camps as the starting point for our process-level analysis. Specifically, we examine how competing teleoaffective structures shape managerial actions and thought patterns to either promote or inhibit consistent alignments of archetypal meanings.

This analysis is facilitated by analytically differentiating between content ideation and content selection as two separate steps of content creation (see Figure 4). We differentiate between brand-driven and customer-oriented approaches during the content ideation stage and argue that they lead to divergent outcomes regarding archetype consistency. True to our qualitative methodology, we make no claims that managers of consistently articulated brand only adopt the brand-driven approach, while managers of ambiguously articulated brands only adopt the customer-oriented approach. Both approaches overlap in our interviews; however, we find that informants from each camp match the above association in their tendencies and have structured the ensuing discussion accordingly.

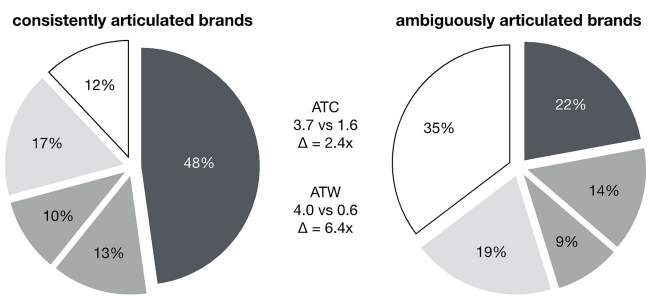
5.2.1 Brand-driven approach: internally-oriented teleoaffective structure promotes archetypal alignment

Managers of consistently articulated brands tend to adopt a brand-driven approach that defines and recurringly utilizes symbolic visual elements to enact archetypes that best express plot-based brand stories (see Figure 4). Brand A's marketing manager strategically defines visual elements, such as the recurring motif of "family gatherings", to consistently enact the "caregiver" archetype on Instagram. And even if no people are shown, specific visual elements such as wine on a large "family table", "multiple glasses of wine", "multiple plates of food" and "family style place setting" are intentionally defined to convey desired brand meanings (see Table 2). At the end of the quote below, she explicitly points out that these visual elements are used "intentionally and strategically":

> Even in imagery that doesn't have people in it, we're still trying to create that kind of family feel. That is evident in a lot of the imagery, where there's kind of food or wine, sitting around a family table, and we try to get that that sense of that wine is to be shared and enjoyed at family settings and family environments [. . .]. We try to have multiple glasses of wine in the shot if you notice, multiple plates of food or a central kind of family style place setting of food that can be shared. Those things are actually done intentionally and strategically (Marketing manager, Brand A).

The social media manager for Brand D offers a similar rationale for posting images in which people drink wine out of mason jars and other non-conventional wine glasses (see Plate 2):

Figure 3 Consistently versus ambiguously articulated brands

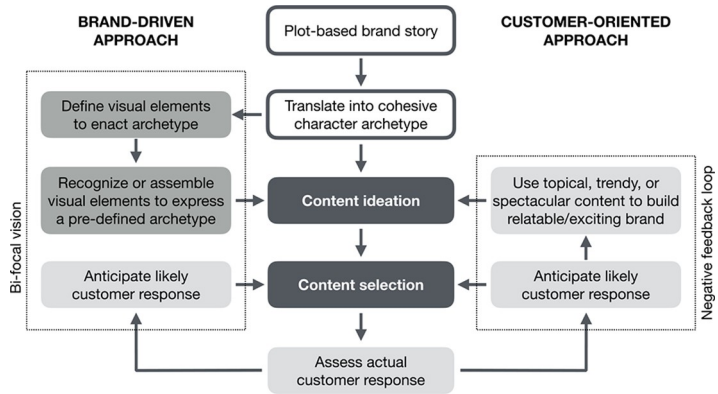


■ = lead archetype, ■ = first and second follow-up archetypes, ■ = all other archetypes and COVID-related, □ = non-archetype.
Archetype consistency (ATC) measures lead AT divided by first follow-up AT; archetype weight (ATW) measures lead AT divided by non-AT.
Consistently articulated brands have 2.4 times stronger ATC measures and 6.4 times higher ATW measures than ambiguously articulated brands: Consistently articulated brands display a dominant lead archetype in about half of their posts (average: 48%) and have a smaller percentage of non-archetype posts (average: 12%; mean ATW = 4.0). These brands also have a considerable gap between their lead and follow-up archetypes, with an average difference of 35 percentage points and a mean ATC of 3.7. By contrast, ambiguously articulated brands predominantly post non-archetypal content (average: 35%), and all these brands post more non-archetypal content than images that conveys their lead archetype (average: 22%; mean ATW = 0.6). The gap between their lead and follow-up archetypes is also much narrower, with only 8 percentage points on average (mean ATC = 1.6).

Source: The authors

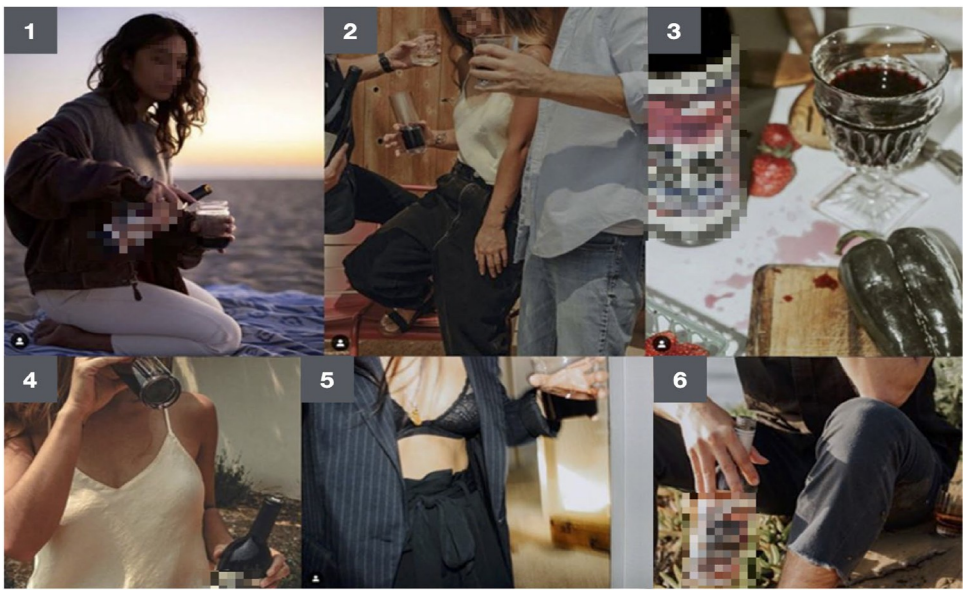
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Figure 4 Processes for consistent vs ambiguous archetype enactments



Source: The authors

Plate 2 Visual elements to enact lead archetype (Brand D)



Note(s): Brand D enacts its Regular Guy/Gal lead archetype through several visual elements to present people and scenes that are unpretentious, not out to impress, and with a common touch: Everyday or thrift glassware to drink wine from (panels 1–5), denim (panels 1, 2, 6), oversized clothing (panel 1, 5), well-worn/wrinkly clothing (panels 2,4,6), everyday locations that have a constricted feel (panels 2–6), well-worn kitchen utensils (panel 3), messy and dirty scenes (panel 3)
Source: Rabble Wines (publicly available Instagram posts)

> That's also something that when building the brand, we were thoughtful about. We want to make this a wine for everybody. And I feel like wine, a lot of the times, has been very posh and you feel like an outsider if you don't know enough. And so, we wanted to have it be very inviting and non-pretentious [. . .]. We wanted to make sure that this was being seen throughout the brand. And, you see, it almost looks like the people are not, you know, typical wine drinkers. A lot of these people, they seem just like normal young people that are enjoying wine. In sort of a non-professional environment, I guess. I mean, that's the whole thing. I remember getting into the wine industry [. . .]. There was a lot of pretentiousness, and we don't want to make anyone feel better than or less than [anyone else] because they know more about wine or not (Social media manager, Brand D).

Again, the choice of visual elements is strategic and intentional. In her quote, the social media manager connects the brand story ("a wine for everybody"; see Table 2) to the "regular guy/gal" archetype through clearly identified visual elements (e.g. mason jars and other non-conventional wine glasses) she strategically uses as props to create a less pretentious atmosphere in her images. Additional visual elements she consciously cultivates in her photo shoots are specific types of clothing (e.g. oversized clothing, denim, t-shirts) and scene details (e.g. food eaten out of take-out boxes, messy tables, heavily used kitchen items; see Plate 2) that convey regular guy/gal aesthetics of "normal young people" who live ordinary and mundane lives.

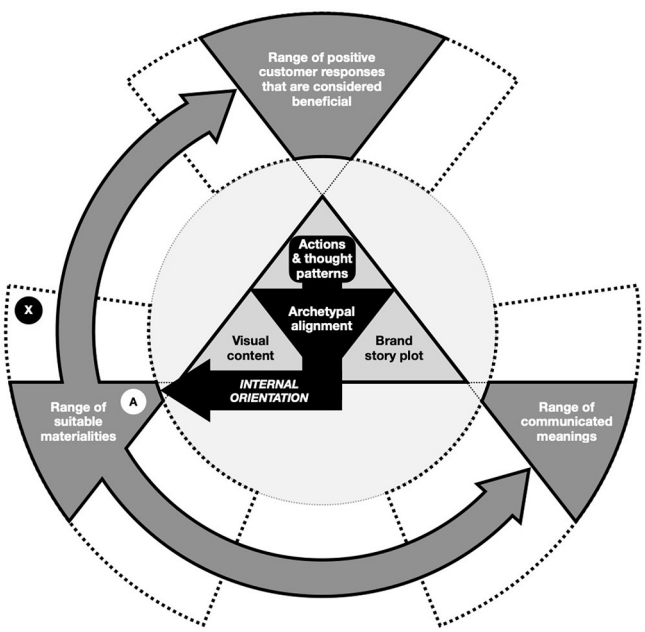
From a practice theoretical perspective, marketers who adopt this brand-driven approach organize the practice of visual

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storytelling according to an internally-oriented teleoaffective structure that foregrounds the maximization of brand consistency as the guiding goal of practice performances. In both quotes above, informants emphasize that they are very intentional and thoughtful about defining symbolic elements to visually express their brand stories, to ensure that desired meanings are "being seen throughout the brand" and its presence on social media. By defining these symbolic elements, managers draw on the shared "pool of understandings" (Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001, p. 58) offered by archetypes, even if only implicitly, thus instituting meanings and organizing the practice of visual storytelling in a fashion we have described in section 5.1.2.

Adopting an internally-oriented teleoaffective structure strategically constrains the range of materialities that are considered as suitable for creating branded content (see black pathway in Figure 5). In the quote above, Brand D's social media manager differentiates "normal young people" from "typical wine drinkers" and associates the latter (rightly or wrongly) with a "the establishment" marked by pretentiousness and elitism. Mason jars, take-out boxes, and other visual elements we noted previously (see Plate 2) are considered by her as suitable materialities (located in Figure 5 via the white dot labelled A) to express meanings consistent with the "regular guy/gal" archetype, or "normal young people" in her vernacular. Conversely, high-status scenes and luxury environments are notably absent from Brand D's Instagram account. This is especially striking considering how easy it would be for the social media manager to create such content: Brand D is the entry level label of a winery that is housed in a modern-day castle in central coast California, complete with arches, crenellations and a moat. This spectacular location is frequently used to create content for a separate Instagram account to promote the winery's more expensive labels (not included in this data set). Both accounts are managed by the same person; yet the castle is never used for Brand D's photoshoots despite being easily accessible. The castle and other visual elements that might signal status and establishment are consciously avoided because they lie outside the range of what the social media manager considers to be suitable materialities to express Brand D (see black dot labelled X in Figure 5). Instead, photos are often staged within private apartments or public beaches (see Plate 2), creating aesthetics of constrained quarters and low-key pleasures that are consistent with the "regular guy/gal" archetype.

Figure 5 Internally-oriented teleoaffective structure maximizes brand consistency



Source: The authors

Adopting this internally-oriented teleoaffective structure balances managers' desire to garner positive customer responses (e.g. likes) with staying focused on expressing brand-specific meanings, or the "personality of the brand". Negotiations between these two goals are visible in the following quote:

> We have this story first, you know, that's our overall story, that is who we are, and it's a foundation. And then we build material around it. You have your UGC or you have images from a specific photoshoot that you'd like to leverage. I think those have to be about the personality of the brand. [. . .] We also want it to have life. And so, we don't want to have this specific formula that we're following, in order to cheat the system of the algorithm. I mean, just because you're cheating the algorithm doesn't mean that people are buying into what you are saying. And I think that's more important (Social media manager, Brand D).

The manager distances her approach from following a "specific formula", even if such formula would result in higher customer engagement. In her view, "cheating the algorithm" to inflate engagement metrics is less important than having people "buying into what you are saying", which she believes is achieved by closely connecting visual "material" to the brand story as a "foundation" (i.e. the black "internal orientation" arrow in Figure 5). By discounting positive engagement if the underlying content does not "have life" or does not reflect the "personality of the brand", she reduces the range of what customer responses she considers beneficial to the brand, even if these would normally be considered positive (see top part of Figure 5). For example, one image by the brand shows a young woman gazing into the distance, naked from her waistline up. Even though this image gathered two to four times more likes than other images posted during the same timeframe, upon reflection, the manager found that this image did not represent the brand well in her eyes. Furthermore, we did not find any other images by this brand that showed bare-chested women.

Altogether, these insights demonstrate how an internally-oriented teleoaffective structure emphasizes archetypal alignment of meanings as the appropriate goal for the practice of visual storytelling (Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001). Focusing on what visual elements and materialities are deemed suitable for the brand reduces what external customer responses are recognized as truly valuable (i.e. only those that are prompted by content which is aligned with desired brand meanings) and overall communicates a more narrowly defined range of meanings to customers (see archetype distribution for consistently articulated brands in Table 2). In the following sub-section, we contrast this internal teleoaffective structure to an alternative external orientation that organizes practice performances in different ways.

5.2.2 Customer-oriented approach: externally-oriented teleoaffective structure inhibits archetypal alignment

Managers of ambiguously articulated brands tend to adopt a customer-oriented approach when identifying content opportunities, thus disconnecting content ideation from

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desired brand meanings (see Figure 4 above). The owner of Brand X explains that she tries to understand "how people are feeling right now and say: we're feeling what you're feeling". Her general tendency to empathize with consumers influences what content opportunities she perceives. When asked what posts best represent her brand story, she offers the following:

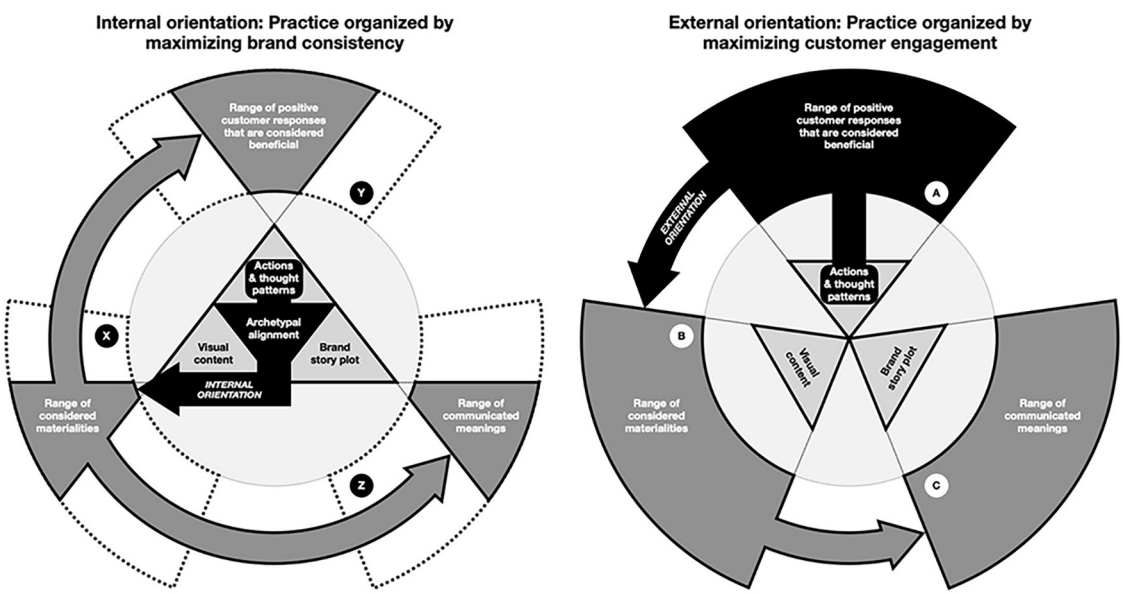
> It was right at the beginning of the pandemic [. . .]. It has a picture of me pulling my hair out, my daughter doing the same thing, my son playing a video game and [my husband] drinking from the [wine] bottle. I was thinking how people felt at that time. It was like, what the hell is happening? The kids at home? I don't know what to do, we're all pulling our hair (Winery Owner, Brand X).

While this post (Web Appendix 4: left panel) may be in-tune with the zeitgeist of that moment, it does not contribute to articulating a cohesive and consistent archetypal gestalt. Brand X predominantly uses the "innocent" (21%) archetype, which is a cohesive translation of their brand story (Table 2). In fact, the owners' children are frequently featured. However, these images usually play into the "innocent" archetype because they convey idealized versions of innocence and play (Web Appendix 4: right panel), not the more cynical portrayal of children being hooked on technological devices and parents who are barely getting-by. Despite the owner's assessment that the above post fits well with their brand story, our archetypal reading suggests that it expresses the "jester" archetype due to its light-hearted humour deployed to show the realities of parenting and struggle with new life conditions during lockdown. While maybe being on point in terms of its social commentary and triggering positive customer responses, this type of post does not present a good fit for Brand X.

Formulaic use of supposedly best-practices can also dilute a brand's archetypal gestalt. Common social media advice is to post flashy content and portray aspirational lifestyles to stimulate customer engagement. From this perspective, an image showing a private helicopter parked on the grounds of Brand Z may seem like good content. Indeed, this post (see Web Appendix 5: left panel) garnered about twice the engagement of the five immediately preceding posts. It is also viewed favourably by the brand's general manager, who embraces the customer-oriented approach through his goal of "post[ing] something interesting or unique" to get "a ton of feedback" (i.e. comments and likes). However, our archetypal analysis challenges the suitability of this post. The luxury and opulence expressed via the private helicopter aligns with the "ruler" archetype, which does not represent a meaningful share of Brand Z's Instagram content and contradicts the brand's leading "caregiver" archetype and plot-based story of being warm and welcoming (see Table 2; Web Appendix 5: right panel). In other words, even though this post seems to fare well in terms of standard customer-response metrics, from an archetypal perspective it dilutes the consistency of the brand's archetypal gestalt and thus broadens the meanings that are communicated to consumers beyond the official brand story.

From a practice theoretical lens, this customer-oriented approach to content ideation is based on a competing teleoaffective structure (Schatzki, 2005) that foregrounds the maximization of customer engagement as the guiding goal of visual storytelling practices. Whereas previously we discussed how an internally-oriented teleoaffective structure constrains the range of materialities and customer responses considered desirable for the brand (see left side of Figure 6), here we describe how an externally-oriented teleoaffective structure prompts managers to prioritize content that is topical, trendy, aspirational, or spectacular in attempts to maximize customer responses (see black pathway on right side of Figure 6). However, by making decisions based on external validation rather than internal strategic guidance, archetypal alignment of meanings is sidelined and a wider range of materialities are incorporated into the practice of visual storytelling, regardless of how well these align with core brand meanings.

Figure 6 Competing teleoaffective structures in visual storytelling practices



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We return to the example of the private helicopter parked on the premises of Brand Z to illustrate the differences between these two competing teleoaffective structures: Adopting the maximization of customer engagement as his guiding principle, the general manager believes that this image would generate "a ton of feedback", which he views as beneficial for the brand (white dot A in Figure 6). However, using this content opportunity incorporates materialities into the visual storytelling practice (the helicopter; white dot B) that are ill-aligned with core brand notions such as providing a "warm, welcoming place to greet and care for our guests" (see Table 2). By visually presenting the winery as a place of luxury and status (white dot C) rather than a "original homestead" that is "steeped in history" (see Table 2), content like this broadens the meanings that are communicated to customers about the brand beyond the officially sanctioned, plot-based brand story. On the left side of Figure 6, we use black dots labelled X to Z to visualize the difference to the previously discussed teleoaffective structure: Maximizing brand consistency as the organizing goal would consider a private helicopter – via a focus on aligning archetypal meanings – to be outside the range of suitable materialities for the brand (black dot X). Hence, practitioners guided by this alternative teleoaffective structure would view the potential engagement that might result from this post as less beneficial for the brand (black dot Y) and refrain from using this content opportunity, thereby avoiding the dilution of brand meanings (black dot Z).

Identifying how practice performances may be organized by different teleoaffective structures deepens our understanding of visual storytelling: While archetypes provide a shared pool of general understandings that *can* align brand storytelling across different text modalities, these shared understandings *need to be activated as organizing principles* to affect actual practice performances.

6. Discussion

This research advances our understandings of visual storytelling from an advertising-production perspective, particularly regarding the role of archetypes in visual storytelling and the *process* of translating *specific* plot-based brand stories into visual content. Our study provides a unique angle to the advertising-production perspective due to its context, methodology and conceptual framework. We deviate from existing research that examines the production of print advertisements (Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) by exploring visual storytelling within social media environments, thereby highlighting the context-specific impact of instant feedback loops on marketing practice (Bartoloni and Ancillai, 2024). Secondly, a unique strength of our research is that we interview managerial decision-makers who are directly responsible for creating the visual content we analyse. Prior research rarely combines managerial interviews with in-depth analysis of visual data (e.g. Aimé, 2023), and those that do (Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) lack the immediate connection between interview and visual data to examine how managerial actions produce specific outcomes. A third innovation of our research is that we examine visual storytelling through an integration of neo-archetype (Faber and Mayer, 2009) and practice theory (Schatzki, 2002). This practice theoretical perspective on archetypes enables a more focused examination into the managerial actions and thought patterns through which brand stories are translated into visual content. Altogether, our research contributes to the literatures on visual storytelling (e.g. Nikulina *et al.*, 2024; Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) and archetypal marketing (e.g. Woodside *et al.*, 2008) by advancing understandings of:

- the role of archetypes in visual storytelling (i.e. archetypes can express differentiated and nuanced brand meanings, but they must be enrolled in storytelling practices to affect how marketers act and what makes sense for them to do); and
- how a visual mix is articulated in marketing practice (i.e. how competing goals can be balanced and what dangers are posed by overly emphasizing customer engagement metrics).

6.1 The role of archetypes in visual storytelling

Our examination demonstrates how archetypes facilitate strategic differentiation by providing the connective tissue necessary for establishing and evaluating alignment between specific plot-based brand stories and concrete visual content. Prior visual storytelling research has examined visual codes related to broader brand positionings such as longevity (Pecot *et al.*, 2022) or luxury appeal (Freire, 2014; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Rokka and Canniford, 2016). Knowing these visual codes enables brands to claim values emblematic of their category but not more brand-specific meanings. Our analysis demonstrates that archetypes can also be expressed through visual codes, thus opening up a large repertoire of cultural building blocks (e.g. 12 main archetypes plus several sub-archetypes for each in Mark and Pearson, [2001] classification system) brands can use to express differentiated and nuanced meanings through their visual communications. The current study thus provides insights into how brands can construct and manage a "rich sign system" (Gurzki *et al.*, 2019, p. 411): Archetypes can serve as an intermediate step that enables marketers and content creators to identify which visual codes best represent their brand stories.

In contrast to more idiosyncratic personal preferences about what visuals may be central to a brand (Phillips *et al.*, 2014), archetypes are grounded in culture (Faber and Mayer, 2009; Mark and Pearson, 2001). In practice theoretical vernacular, archetypes are "broad cultural conceptions which transcend the boundaries between 'integrative practices'" (Welch and Warde, 2016, p. 183). They thereby not only inform the practical intelligibility of marketers who perform visual story*telling* practices but also the practical intelligibility of consumers who perform visual story*reading* practices, such as scrolling through Instagram. While prior studies have demonstrated that consumers can indeed decode archetypal meanings from visuals (e.g. Faber and Mayer, 2009; Megehee and Spake, 2012), our research focuses on how archetypal meanings are encoded by marketers.

On this note, our findings emphasize a key distinction between how archetypes are decoded versus encoded in marketing practice: Archetypes must be enrolled into storytelling practices to affect how marketers act and what makes sense for them to do. This practice-theoretical view evolves traditional archetype research,

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which typically assumes that the encoding of archetypes into marketing communications is achieved just as automatically as consumers can decode archetypes (Faber and Mayer, 2009; Megehee and Spake, 2012). Woodside *et al.* (2008), for example, suggest that archetypes affect both "consumer and brand enactment, mostly unconsciously" (p. 111), thus taking for granted that brands can encode archetypes unproblematically and even non-consciously in their communications. This assumption is rooted in an understanding that archetypes are grounded in culture and thus operate at an automatic level (Faber and Mayer, 2009; Mark and Pearson, 2001). While this may be adequate for when consumers decode archetypes presented to them, the act of encoding archetypes during advertising production is marked by competing goals and material infrastructures which can, as shown by this research, sideline archetypal understandings and alignments.

Our practice-theoretical view therefore highlights that archetypes are not only grounded in culture but also culture-in-practice (Schatzki, 2002): As general understandings that "are experienced, articulated and negotiated in situated and embodied activity [i.e. practices] and thereby transpose the cultural to situated activity" (Welch and Warde, 2016, p. 195), archetypes must be enrolled into visual storytelling practices to make archetypal alignments practically intelligible for brand managers and creatives. The current study suggests two material infrastructures that promote archetypal alignments of meanings: explicitly operationalizing archetypes into visual elements and, potentially, the use of input metrics that measure how well branded content enacts archetypes over time. Future research may explore additional ways in which archetypes can be enrolled into visual storytelling practices.

6.2 How a visual mix is articulated, and competing goals are balanced

Existing research emphasizes the need to create a unique and consistent visual mix (Pecot *et al.*, 2022; Phillips *et al.*, 2014) but does not examine how decision-makers accomplish this task in marketing practice. Contextual factors such as brand identity, personal taste preferences or product category are identified as forces that may impact visual mix articulation; yet the actions brand representatives perform to translate brand meanings into visual content, and whether and why these efforts are effective, have remained unexplored thus far. Our process analysis suggests that a brand-driven approach to content ideation, in which marketers define concrete visual elements for enacting desired archetypal meanings, enables marketers to articulate their brands more consistently. Managers who tend towards using a customer-oriented approach, on the other hand, fuel a negative feedback loop because anticipated customer responses drive both content ideation and content selection (see Figure 4), which increases risks of diluting their brand's archetypal gestalt.

These findings extend our understandings of conflicts within visual marketing and how they can be managed. Phillips *et al.* (2014) noted that inter-organizational conflicts can arise between brand management and external agencies when formulating a brand's visual identity, while Aimé (2023) discusses intra-organizational conflicts between different members within the same company. By contrast, our study observes an intra-personal conflict, in which a single practitioner is pulled between competing goals, emotions and normative expectations (Schatzki, 2005): Due to readily available customer-response metrics, an external force (Pecot *et al.*, 2022) specific to social media environments but absent from traditional print campaigns, tensions between competing teleoaffective structures of maximizing brand consistency versus maximizing customer engagement are heightened. Given the intertwined nature of practices and material arrangements, conflicts between competing teleoaffective structures are often shaped by material infrastructures that support one teleoaffective orientation over another (Schatzki, 2005). In our study, easily accessible social media metrics offer material support for externally-oriented teleoaffective structures, thus making it likely that maximizing engagement goals dominate over internal orientations of maximizing brand consistency.

A key difference between consistently and ambiguously articulated brands in our study is that the former have translated brand meanings into clearly articulated visual elements (e.g. using mason jars instead of wine glasses to express meanings associated with the "regular guy/gal" archetype; see Plate 2). Managers of more ambiguous brands were also able to describe what their brands stand for, but they used rather abstract descriptions (e.g. "whimsical", "elevated", "clever" or "future of tradition" for Brand Y) without translating these into concrete visual elements that could be inserted into brand images. Drawing on practice theory, we theorize that clearly defining visual elements creates additional material resources – for example articulated in a style guide (Phillips *et al.*, 2014) or throughout the brand's social media page – that can counter the effects of customer-response metrics and therefore help balance between both teleoaffective structures (Schatzki, 2005). Buttressed by an internal orientation, even foregoing heightened customer engagement opportunities can become practically intelligible (Schatzki and E. von Savigny, 2001; Welch and Warde, 2016) to marketers if the additional "likes" are seen as compromising brand consistency.

With this, a related contribution of this study is that we problematize the dangers of overly relying on customer-response metrics. While measuring performance is essential (Hollebeek and Macky, 2019), there are growing concerns about how analytics can be best used to secure long-term brand value (Vollrath and Villegas, 2022). Our study adds to this discussion by highlighting that overly relying on customer-response metrics fuels a negative feedback loop which dilutes brands' archetypal gestalt (see Figure 4). Marketers have become well-aware of the sudden and immediate harm consumer-generated content may pose to brand value (Scholz and Smith, 2019). However, the potential that marketers themselves slowly dilute brand meanings by blindly subjecting owned media content to the unchecked dictate of customer-response metrics has been a thus-far under-recognized threat to brand value. The input metrics we develop in this research may offer additional material infrastructures (Schatzki, 2005) that can mitigate this threat.

6.3 Future research opportunities

More research is necessary to better understand how managers select and enact archetypes for storytelling. Brands in our dataset are mostly able to cohesively match their plot-based

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stories with suitable archetypes; however, we also find that some brands prioritize non-ideal archetypes (e.g. Brand C; see Table 2). People often intuitively recognize and understand archetypes (Faber and Mayer, 2009) and prior research assumes that managers can utilize archetypes non-consciously (Woodside *et al.*, 2008). Yet, to our knowledge, no research has thus far examined how differences in personal or organizational knowledge and skills – internal factors in the terminology of Pecot *et al.* (2022) – would affect archetype enactment and strategy alignment. Finally, while the current article deliberately takes an advertising-production, future research could experimentally assess consumers' reactions to consistently versus ambiguously articulated brands. We expect that consumers would react more favourably towards brands that consistently enact a specific archetype, especially if they (want to) embody this archetype in their own lives (Faber and Mayer, 2009; Woodside *et al.*, 2008).

6.4 Managerial implications

The insights offered by this research provide several benefits for telling brand stories on image-heavy marketing channels (e.g. social media, product packaging) across a large number of industries, as archetypes are universal building blocks of culture that are used by brands of all kinds (Mark and Pearson, 2001; Merlo *et al.*, 2023). Our framework enables marketers to close the strategy-execution gap by selecting an archetype that best matches their brand's story and then defining specific visual elements to enact this archetype. Defining visual elements aligns communications efforts across multiple actors (Aimé, 2023) by translating abstract brand meanings into actionable content guidelines: Band managers, for example, could more clearly articulate their "mandatories" to creative agencies and social media influencers to improve coordination (Phillips *et al.*, 2014; Scholz, 2021). Defining visual elements can also guide decisions regarding what consumer-generated content should be amplified by the brand, and what opportunities should be avoided (Rokka and Canniford, 2016). For example, amplifying "flashy" content might seem like a good idea when following standard Instagram advice, but it may conflict with the brand's lead archetype and thus dilute brand value.

Managers can furthermore use the metrics we introduce in this paper to measure how well their brand positioning is realized and identify shortcomings in existing visual content. Suitable benchmarks managers could aim for would be an ATC of 4, which is the average score for consistently articulated brands in this study (see Table 2), and an ATW of 6, which is slightly higher than the observed average in this study. We recommend a higher ATW because the insights presented in this article empower managers to easily transform non-archetypal images into lead archetype images, for example by embedding products into more complex scenes rather than showing them against a simple coloured background. Defining benchmarks for these input metrics would complement more traditional customer-response metrics by providing real-time insights into how consistently a brand is visually operationalized, while still allowing for flexibility in day-today executions.

7. Conclusion

Visual storytelling has become increasingly important over the last few years (Grigsby *et al.*, 2023; Gurzki *et al.*, 2019; Nikulina *et al.*, 2024; Scholz, 2025) and is likely here to stay. This shift necessitates new understandings for how brand stories can be told without complex narrative plots but still in line with core brand meanings. Archetypes provide a rich cultural system for translating specific brand stories into visual content; however, marketers must enrol archetypal alignments in their storytelling practices to create a consistent archetypal gestalt for their brands.

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Further reading

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Supplementary material

The supplementary material for this article can be found online.

About the authors

Joachim Scholz is Assistant Professor of Marketing at Brock University, Canada. He holds a PhD in Marketing from Queen's University, Canada, is a research scholar and Fellow at the Cool Climate Oenology and Viticulture Institute at Brock University, board member at York University's Future of Marketing Institute and member of Adweek's Academic Council. His research interests focus on augmented reality marketing, visual storytelling, influencer marketing, social media controversies, and branding in digital/phygital worlds. Scholz has published in the *Journal of Business Research*, *Journal of Advertising Research*, *Journal of Marketing Management* and other leading marketing research outlets. He published the first-ever conceptual article on Augmented Reality Marketing in 2016, which won Best Article of the Year award. At Brock University, he teaches the world's first dedicated Augmented Reality Marketing courses at the undergraduate and MBA levels, which was awarded the 2020 MABDA Innovation in Business Education Award. Joachim Scholz is the corresponding author and can be contacted at: jscholz@brocku.ca

Antonia Mantonakis is Professor of Marketing and Consumer Psychology at Brock University, Canada, and serves as a Fellow at Brock University's Cool Climate Oenology and Viticulture Institute. She holds a PhD in Experimental Cognitive Psychology from Simon Fraser University, Canada. Mantonakis has contributed significantly to the academic community through publications in top tier marketing and psychology journals, including the *Journal of Marketing Research* and *Psychological Science*. She was a visiting scholar at the Booth School of Business, University of Chicago, where she was a Kilts Fellow. She has also held the position of Associate Research Fellow in Consumer Insights and Product Innovation at the Vineland Research and Innovation Centre. She achieved a remarkable milestone by becoming the first to be awarded two Canadian Tri-Council research grants (national competition; NSERC + SSHRC) as a new Assistant Professor.

Jacob Gigliotti is a Professional Oenologist and Export Sales Manager at Pillitteri Estates Winery, Niagara-on-the-Lake, Canada. He received a Bachelor of Science degree from Brock University, specializing on wine production and wine marketing. He has presented his academic research on wine marketing at the American Marketing Association, Consumer Culture Theory, International Cool Climate Wine Consortium and Academy of Wine Business Research conferences. At Pillitteri Estates Winery, he regularly hosts wine education events and supports the master wine maker as well as the general manager in all operational aspects related to running the winery.

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